

Two of his sons became active in English politics. They won a seat that the family held for 85 years, from 1912 to 1997. It was known in the House of Commons as Guinness-on-Sea.

Walter Guinness was Britain's agriculture minister during the 1920s.

The family members were active philanthropists. They donated estates to the Irish and English governments and gave generously to charitable foundations.

But they were becoming increasingly disconnected from the business.

Edward's three granddaughters, the "Golden Guinness Girls," who came of age in the late 1920s and early 1930s, were the Paris Hiltons of their generation. They were spoiled rich girls who became involved in various public scandals. They also had a tragic streak: each had a child who died from an illness or accident.

In the early twentieth century, the board of directors was still filled with Guinness family members. But they became increasingly insular and lacked sufficient knowledge and experience to competently lead the business. The shares were being divided between the sons of each generation. And family ownership was being diluted by mergers and expansion.

Rupert Guinness successfully led the company for 35 years. The *Guinness Book of World Records* was launched under his management. Rupert was chairman until 1962, at age 88. His younger brother and his son had been killed in World War II. So Rupert waited for his grandson, Benjamin Guinness, to reach an age at which he could take over the reins of the company. He was appointed chairman at 25, just four years after joining the business. He was a shy man who evidently wanted to become a farmer. He was not a shrewd businessman.

He tried to diversify the company outside of alcoholic beverages, which was a big mistake.

By the 1970s, the business was in bad shape, and profits were collapsing.

Since going public, management of the brewery had been passed down from father to son(s) for 100 years. Then, in 1986, Benjamin hired an outsider, Ernest Saunders, to be CEO. Saunders was an experienced executive from Nestle.

Saunders did turn the business around. He focused on selling the core stout beer.